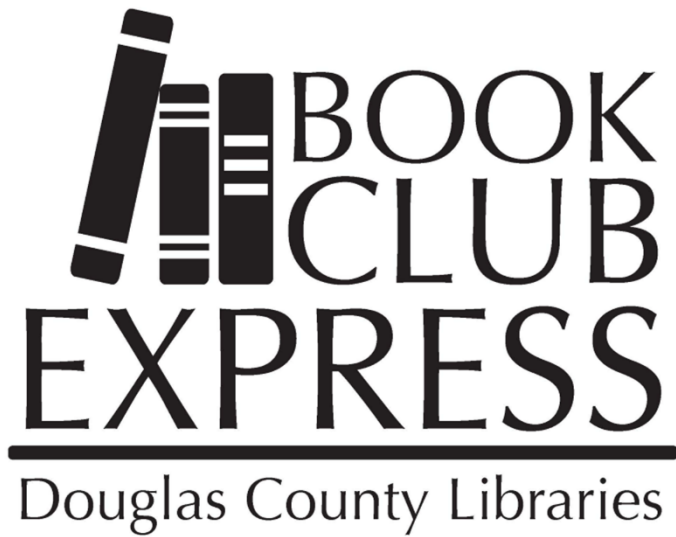




Strangers in Time

by David Baldacci

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Dear Reader,

I've been an Anglophile for a long time, having cut my youthful reader's teeth on British writers like Agatha Christie, Arthur Conan Doyle, H.G. Wells, Ian Fleming, George Orwell, J.R.R. Tolkien, Lewis Carroll, Daniel Defoe, Charles Dickens and many more. With that in mind, I remember sitting down with a writing journal one cold winter's eve and staring at the enticingly blank pages, much as I did with another historical novel of mine, *A Calamity of Souls*, a courtroom drama set in Virginia in 1968.

Strangers in Time is set in 1944 in London, where World War II had left its ferocious imprint like it had on few cities. Now, in truth, innumerable novels have been written about the war, and it is a challenge for any writer to come up with anything new to write about that time. How I hopefully solved that challenge was to center the tale on three very different characters and for what I believed would be a unique purpose.

They are Charlie Matters, a lad from Bethnal Green in the hardscrabble East End of London; Molly Wakefield, a girl from Chelsea in the fashionable West End of the city; and Ignatius Oliver, a widower who runs a small bookshop in the Strand, roughly halfway between Charlie's and Molly's worlds. Now, war is difficult on everyone, but there are degrees of difficulty. And since Charlie was poor and Molly was wealthy, their experiences started out as being very dissimilar. Ignatius' experiences are, again, in between the two extremes of Charlie and Molly.

With that framework set I then proceeded in the novel to blow it all up, much like the German bombs dropped on London did to that city. Charlie lost what little he had; Molly lost all that she had; and Ignatius, childless and bereaved and wondering what, if anything, he had left to contribute to life, finds himself in the precarious position of having two teenagers as his wards in one of the most battle-scarred metropolises on earth.

War is a great equalizer of the lives of those it impacts. It does not care about wealth, power or position. It does not care about familial ties. A war's goal is only to destroy people and all that they have.

It was my intent to show that people from all sorts of different backgrounds can form the unlikeliest and most unbreakable bonds of faith and friendship when circumstances like a world war have carved the "human" element straight out of humanity. And, of course, the ultimate goal is to claw that human part back into one's life.

We are sometimes at our best during the worst of times, when the choices we make, the friendships we form and the sacrifices we undergo matter more than ever. And although humans have gotten awfully good at inflicting terrible damage on one another, the reaction to such deplorable circumstances is often seen in small but important examples of the best that humanity can inspire.

Charlie, Molly and Ignatius are quite different from one another, and, in peaceful times, may never have even met. Yet they come together to survive a horrific time in history, that alone, they probably never stood a chance of withstanding.

People are sometimes most resilient when their lives are the darkest. It is a lesson to us all that no matter how dire times may be, including a world war, we need not go through them alone. There is courage, strength and empathy when we stand not simply by ourselves, but hand in hand with others we have come to trust.

Because no matter how destructive the weapons of war surely are, they are helpless before that one crowning attribute of humanity: the power of love.

Sincerely,

David Baldacci

Discussion Questions

1. World War II is such a pivotal moment in history for the world, and it's one that everyone learns about. But was there something you discovered that you were unaware of while reading *Strangers in Time*? If yes, what was it and how did it change your perspective of the war?
2. In times of crisis, it's not about your circumstances prior that determine how you'll survive, it's the choices you make and the people around you. How do you think Charlie, Molly, and Ignatius would have fared if they hadn't met each other?
3. Molly was sent to the countryside at the start of the war, but when she returns, she finds both of her parents gone and a city that no longer looks as she remembers it. Was there ever a time in your life where everything you knew changed? How did you get through that period in your life?
4. Charlie has found himself alone in this dangerous world and he has a hard time trusting others. Why do you think he finally opened up to Molly and Ignatius? Was there ever a moment where you had to take the leap and put your trust in someone new? How did you let go and let that person in?
5. Ignatius sat every day wanting to finish his late wife's novel, but couldn't find the right words to type. How did his grief hold him back, not just in writing the novel, but in living his life, especially during such a harrowing time when one needs to embrace every moment they have?
6. By the end of the book, Charlie and Molly have a bond that has stayed strong, even as the years have gone by and they've created their own families away from each other. Who in your life holds a similar place in your heart and is someone you can return to, time and time again, no matter where your separate lives take you?
7. How did you feel when you learned the truth about Ignatius' wife and her activities? Did it make you think differently about Ignatius himself?
8. Charlie, Molly, and Ignatius all feel an intense need to contribute to the war efforts, whether it's Charlie wanting to enlist to fight the Nazis, Molly putting her nursing skills to use, or Ignatius being a warden who helps guide Londoners to bomb shelters and assists those injured. But there doesn't have to be war for someone to want to contribute to something important. What's something that you're passionate about and you strive to make better in the world?

9. Molly and Charlie come from very different socioeconomic worlds; he's an East End lad with very little, while the West End Molly grew up in luxury. The novel shows that war can render what one materially possesses meaningless. What lessons can readers draw from this on a personal level?

10. The title *Strangers in Time* alludes to people who didn't know one another, surreptitiously coming together just in the nick of time, to allow them to be supportive of one another in getting through the war. Have you met someone during a difficult time in your life whom you felt made a positive difference? And if you had not met that person how different would your life have been?

11. Charlie and Molly are still children in the novel, but they have to grow up very quickly and act more like adults. Have you ever had life situations that forced you to do something similar? What do you think the pros and cons of having to do that are?

12. Molly and Charlie have remained lifelong friends, but friendships of that nature change over time. Do you have friendships of a long-term nature and how have they evolved as the years have gone by?

13. The novel speaks to the ability of people to adapt to almost any situation, in this case years of bombing, death and destruction. How do you think going through such an ordeal may change people? Will it make them less trusting, more independent, more, or less, cynical, or more confident in their abilities to weather any storm?

Author Biography

David Baldacci has been writing since childhood, when his mother gave him a lined notebook in which to write down his stories. Many years later, when David thanked her for being the spark that ignited his writing career, she revealed that she'd given him the notebook to keep him quiet, "because every mom needs a break now and then."

David published his first novel, *Absolute Power*, in 1996. The feature film adaptation followed, with Clint Eastwood as its director and star. In total, David has published 54 novels for adults; all have been national and international bestsellers, and several have been adapted for film and television. His novels are published in over 45 languages and in more than 80 countries, with over 200 million copies sold worldwide. David has also published seven novels for young readers.

A lifelong Virginian, David received his Bachelor's degree from Virginia Commonwealth University and his law degree from the University of Virginia School of Law, after which he practiced law in Washington, D.C.

In addition to being a prolific writer, David is a devoted philanthropist, and his greatest efforts are dedicated to his family's Wish You Well Foundation®. Established by David and his wife, Michelle, the Wish You Well Foundation supports family and adult literacy programs in the United States. In 2008 the Foundation partnered with Feeding America to launch Feeding Body & Mind, a program to address the connection between literacy, poverty and hunger. Through Feeding Body & Mind, more than 1 million new and gently used books have been collected and distributed through food banks to families in need.

David and his family live in Virginia.

Reviews

Thriller writer Baldacci (*To Die For*) turns to historical fiction with the arresting story of an unlikely trio who come together in 1944 after their lives were transformed by the London Blitz. Charlie Matters, an orphaned, street-smart 13-year-old, lives with his grandmother and uses his wits to survive. After Charlie steals money and a book from widower Ignatius Oliver's bookshop, he returns everything out of guilt and Oliver befriends him. Molly Wakefield, 15, returns to London after a yearslong evacuation in the countryside to discover that both her parents are missing. She meets Charlie on the street and asks him to guide her to the government office where she believes her father works, but he's nowhere to be found. Later, while looking for Charlie, Molly meets Oliver, who's impressed by her maturity and kindness. After Charlie's grandmother dies and Molly's home is destroyed by another round of German bombings, Oliver takes in the two teenagers. As the three weather more assaults on the city, the author illustrates the horrors of war and the utter helplessness of citizens in the face of such daunting challenges. Though the novel is marred by an unnecessary and far-fetched plot twist near the end, Baldacci's strong character work highlights the trio's courage and tenacity, as do the wrenching depictions of London's wartime devastation. It's a touching tale of a found family.

Read-Alikes

Nineteen Steps by Millie Bobby Brown

Inspired by her own family history, *Stranger Things* star Millie Bobby Brown's debut novel tells the story of Nellie Morris, a young woman in London's East End trying to survive the Blitz, her romance with a dashing American airman, and the tragic 1943 Bethnal Green disaster, where 173 people were crushed to death trying to enter an air raid shelter.

The Martha's Vineyard Beach and Book Club by Martha Hall Kelly

In 2016, grieving Mari Starwood visits Martha's Vineyard and uncovers a surprising connection to the Smith sisters, who, during World War II, balanced family struggles, romance, and whispers of espionage while running a farm and forming a transformative book club.

The Lost English Girl by Julia Kelly

During WWII, Viv Byrne, with her husband serving in the Royal Air Force, discovers the countryside safe haven she sent her daughter to wasn't immune from the horrors of war, and it is only years later, with his help, that she learns what it will take to put their family back together again.

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